

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Ethics and Human Interface - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / WORKBOOK INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

Ethics and Human Interface - Solved Practice Workbook	3
BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION	3
CORE DRILLS 1-24	3
REMEDIAL DRILLS 25-32	16
ANSWER KEY AND ROTATION AUDIT	21
PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE	21
OWNERSHIP AND VERIFICATION LEDGER	21
ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS	26
WORD-COUNT AND CATEGORY AUDIT	30

Ethics and Human Interface - Solved Practice Workbook

Subject: Ethics · **Section:** Subject-wide Syllabus · **Paper:** GS-IV **Companion:** learning_package_final\Ethics\Subject-wide-Syllabus\01-Ethics-and-Human-Interface\Learning-Session.md

How this workbook is built. It contains exactly **32 original questions before the PYQ section** - 24 core drills numbered 1-24 and 8 remedial drills numbered 25-32 that target the predictable mistakes recorded in the learning session's trap boxes. The answer key runs in the strict rotation A -> B -> C -> D repeated eight times: ABCDABCDABCDABCDABCDABCDABCDABCD, eight of each option. Every question carries four options, a separate question-specific explanation for **each** of the four options, and its own unique examiner trap. Formats are deliberately varied: two- and three-statement evaluation, matching, elimination, chronology, application, evidence-attribution and inference.

Source discipline. Every factual option is traceable to the 2nd ARC, 4th Report, *Ethics in Governance* (January 2007), Chapter 1, paragraphs 1.1-1.22 and Box 2.3, read directly from books\ethics4.pdf; to the canonical Basic and Advanced owners; to the routed PYQ ledgers; or to a dated official source. Nothing is invented.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

CORE DRILLS 1-24

MCQ 1

The Second ARC's Fourth Report defines ethics and then immediately qualifies the definition. Which statement most accurately reproduces the *qualification* the Commission attaches?

- **A.** The crux of ethical behaviour lies not in bold words enshrined as standards but in their adoption in action, in sanctions against violations, in competent disciplinary bodies that act quickly, and in promoting a culture of integrity.
- **B.** Ethical behaviour follows automatically once a comprehensive code of conduct has been notified for every organ of government, because a standard published in the official gazette both informs officials of their obligations and supplies the disciplinary authority with a ready basis for action in every case of deviation.
- **C.** Ethics is a purely private matter of conscience, so public standards can only describe conduct and never improve it.
- **D.** Standards guarantee ethical behaviour provided that the society enforcing them is economically developed.

Answer: A

Option-by-option explanation

- **A - correct.** ARC 1.1 states that ethics is "a set of standards that society places on itself", then warns that "standards do not, by themselves, ensure ethical behaviour; that requires a robust culture of integrity", and locates the crux in adoption in action, sanctions, competent disciplinary bodies acting quickly, and a culture of integrity. All four elements appear in this option.
- **B - wrong.** Notification of a code is exactly the "bold words and expressions enshrined as standards" that ARC 1.1 says is *not* the crux. The report's whole point is that a notified code without enforcement machinery changes nothing.
- **C - wrong.** The ARC's definition is explicitly social, not private: standards are what "society places on itself". Treating ethics as purely private contradicts the definition in the first sentence of the chapter.
- **D - wrong.** The report attaches no economic precondition to ethical behaviour. It attaches an institutional one - sanctions and disciplinary machinery - and it separately argues that ethical governance itself raises growth, which is the reverse of this option's causal order.

Trap: The stem asks for the *qualification*, not the definition. Candidates who scan for the familiar phrase "standards that society places on itself" pick a definitional option and lose the mark that the second half of ARC 1.1 was set to test.

MCQ 2

Consider the following two statements about the etymology used in the Second ARC's Fourth Report.

1. "Ethics" derives from the Greek *ethikos*, meaning "arising from habit".
2. "Corrupt" derives from the Latin *corruptus*, meaning "to break or destroy".

Which of the statements is/are correct?

- A. 1 only
- B. Both 1 and 2
- C. 2 only
- D. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: B

Option-by-option explanation

- **A - wrong.** Statement 1 is correct, but rejecting statement 2 discards the second half of ARC 1.2, which gives *corruptus* precisely the sense "to break or destroy".
- **B - correct.** ARC 1.2 supplies both derivations in a single sentence, and then uses them together: because ethics arises from habit, the report calls it "unfortunate that corruption has, for many, become a matter of habit".
- **C - wrong.** Statement 2 alone is incomplete; the Greek derivation in statement 1 is equally the report's own and is the one that carries the analytical weight about habituation.
- **D - wrong.** Both derivations are stated verbatim in ARC 1.2, so rejecting both contradicts the primary source.

Trap: Two-statement questions in this area often reverse the languages, attaching Latin to "ethics" and Greek to "corrupt". Fix the pairing by meaning: *habit* is Greek, *breaking* is Latin.

MCQ 3

The Second ARC's terms of reference on ethics in governance covered three heads. Which statement correctly describes how the Fourth Report actually dealt with them?

- A. All three heads - vigilance and corruption, the political executive and permanent civil service relationship, and codes of conduct for the different organs of government - were deferred in their entirety to the Commission's later report on Civil Services Reforms, so that the Fourth Report confined itself to a statement of general ethical principles.
- B. Only the head on codes of conduct was examined, and the other two were dropped entirely.
- C. Vigilance and corruption and codes of conduct were examined in considerable detail, while the political executive-permanent civil service relationship was deferred to the report on Civil Services Reforms.
- D. The relationship between the political executive and the permanent civil service was the sole subject examined in detail.

Answer: C

Option-by-option explanation

- **A - wrong.** ARC 1.19 says the opposite: two of the three heads were examined "in considerable detail" in this very Report.
- **B - wrong.** Vigilance and corruption was examined too. This option drops head A, which supplies the entire anti-corruption architecture of the report.
- **C - correct.** ARC 1.18 lists the three heads - (A) Vigilance and Corruption, (B) Relationship between Political Executive and Permanent Civil Service, (C) Code of Conduct for different organs of Government - and ARC 1.19 states that "items A & C" were examined in considerable detail while "item B will be dealt with comprehensively in the ARC's report on Civil Services Reforms".
- **D - wrong.** Head B is exactly the one that was *not* examined here. This option inverts the report's own statement.

Trap: The deferred head is the politically most interesting one, which is why candidates assume it was the report's centrepiece. Remember the pairing: A and C were done here; B went to Civil Services Reforms.

MCQ 4

Arrange the following in correct chronological order.

1. India ratifies the United Nations Convention against Corruption.
2. The UN General Assembly adopts the United Nations Convention against Corruption.
3. The Second ARC's Fourth Report, *Ethics in Governance*, is published.
4. India endorses the ADB-OECD Anti-Corruption Action Plan for Asia and the Pacific.

- A. 2 - 4 - 3 - 1
- B. 4 - 3 - 2 - 1
- C. 1 - 2 - 4 - 3
- D. 4 - 2 - 3 - 1

Answer: D

Option-by-option explanation

- **A - wrong.** It places the UNCAC adoption of October 2003 before the ADB-OECD endorsement of 30 November 2001, reversing the first two events.
- **B - wrong.** It puts the January 2007 report before the October 2003 adoption of UNCAC, although the report itself cites that adoption at paragraph 1.14 as an existing instrument.
- **C - wrong.** It places India's ratification first. Ratification occurred on 9 May 2011, after every other event in the list.
- **D - correct.** ADB-OECD endorsement, 30 November 2001; UNCAC adopted by the UN General Assembly, 31 October 2003; the Second ARC's Fourth Report, January 2007; India's ratification of UNCAC, 9 May 2011.

Trap: India *signed* UNCAC on 9 December 2005 but *ratified* it only on 9 May 2011, which is why the report speaks of a convention India had joined without India being a full party. Treating signature as ratification collapses two events six years apart.

MCQ 5

A state training institute reports that a large share of field staff regard small facilitation payments as normal practice. An officer argues that the practice is therefore acceptable. Which is the most precise description of the error?

- A. A descriptive finding about prevailing belief has been used as a normative justification, crossing the is-ought gap.
- B. A meta-ethical claim about the meaning of "wrong" has been mistaken for an empirical survey result.
- C. An applied-ethics conclusion has been drawn without first settling a question of moral semantics.
- D. The officer has correctly applied normative ethics but has used an inadequate sample.

Answer: A

Option-by-option explanation

- **A - correct.** The survey establishes what staff in fact believe, which is descriptive ethics. The officer's conclusion is about what may be done, which is normative. Moving from the first to the second without a justifying standard is the is-ought error.
- **B - wrong.** No claim about the meaning or truth-status of moral language has been made. Meta-ethics is not engaged at any point in the scenario.
- **C - wrong.** Applied ethics does not require moral semantics to be settled first; the ARC itself proceeds directly to administrative application without any meta-ethical preliminary.
- **D - wrong.** The defect is logical, not statistical. Even a perfectly representative sample of belief would establish nothing about what ought to be done.

Trap: The word "therefore" is the whole question. Candidates who focus on the plausibility of facilitation payments miss that the stem is testing the inference, not the practice.

MCQ 6

Two probationers argue about whether the word "integrity" can be true or false in the way a factual statement can, without reference to any pending decision. Their debate belongs to which level of ethical enquiry?

- **A.** Descriptive ethics
- **B.** Meta-ethics
- **C.** Applied ethics
- **D.** Normative ethics

Answer: B

Option-by-option explanation

- **A - wrong.** Descriptive ethics would require them to be reporting what some group actually believes about integrity, which is not what the stem describes.
- **B - correct.** They are debating the meaning and truth-status of a moral term, which is exactly the meta-ethical question of whether moral language states facts or expresses attitudes.
- **C - wrong.** Applied ethics requires a concrete field and a live decision. The stem expressly removes any pending decision.
- **D - wrong.** Normative ethics would require them to be arguing what someone ought to do and on what ground; they are arguing about what a word does.

Trap: Meta-ethics feels like the "deepest" level and is therefore over-selected in questions where a decision is actually at stake. Use the reverse test as well: when a live administrative decision is present, meta-ethics is almost never the answer.

MCQ 7

A hospital administrator must decide whether to publish a surgery waiting list despite staff discomfort. Which level of ethical enquiry is she conducting, and why?

- **A.** Descriptive ethics, because the administrator's first task is to record how staff and patients presently feel about disclosure, and an accurate account of those prevailing attitudes is by itself what settles whether the waiting list should be published.
- **B.** Meta-ethics, because the meaning of fairness is contested.
- **C.** Applied ethics, because a normative standard of fairness and transparency is being worked out for a specific institutional decision.
- **D.** None, because the question is purely administrative rather than ethical.

Answer: C

Option-by-option explanation

- **A - wrong.** Staff discomfort is a fact in the background of the decision, not the object of the enquiry. She is not conducting a survey.
- **B - wrong.** She is applying a standard of fairness, not analysing what the word "fairness" means or whether it can be true.
- **C - correct.** Applied ethics is normative theory worked out for a definite field - here, medical and administrative practice - by testing a concrete decision rather than by naming a theory.
- **D - wrong.** The decision allocates a scarce public good and affects identifiable persons unequally, which makes it ethical as well as administrative; the two are not alternatives.

Trap: "Purely administrative" is a standing distractor in GS-IV. Almost every allocation decision carries duty, fairness and accountability dimensions, so the option that denies an ethical question is nearly always wrong.

MCQ 8

Match each dimension of a public decision with the failure it is designed to catch.

Dimension	Failure caught
1. Consequences	i. Silent, unexplained unequal treatment
2. Justice and fairness	ii. A procedurally correct decision that ignores the most vulnerable claimant
3. Care and empathy	iii. Good intentions accompanied by foreseeable harm
4. Accountability	iv. A decision that survives only while it remains unexamined

- **A.** 1-i, 2-ii, 3-iii, 4-iv
- **B.** 1-ii, 2-iii, 3-iv, 4-i
- **C.** 1-iv, 2-i, 3-ii, 4-iii
- **D.** 1-iii, 2-i, 3-ii, 4-iv

Answer: D

Option-by-option explanation

- **A - wrong.** It attaches unequal treatment to the consequences dimension. Unequal treatment is caught by justice and fairness, which asks whether like cases are treated alike.
- **B - wrong.** It makes accountability responsible for detecting unequal treatment. Accountability tests whether reasons can be stated publicly and reviewed; fairness tests the distribution itself.
- **C - wrong.** It assigns non-reviewability to the consequences dimension, whereas foreseeable harm is precisely what consequence-reasoning exists to detect.
- **D - correct.** Consequences catch foreseeable harm despite good intentions; justice and fairness catch unexplained unequal treatment; care and empathy catch procedural correctness that is blind to the vulnerable; accountability catches decisions that survive only in the absence of scrutiny.

Trap: Matching questions on dimensions punish candidates who memorise the list without the function of each item. Learn each dimension by the *failure it detects*, not by its name.

MCQ 9

A procurement officer attends a lavish private dinner hosted by a firm bidding for a contract in his jurisdiction. No payment is made and no rule is shown to be violated. Which assessment is most defensible?

- **A.** The conduct may satisfy legality yet fail propriety, because it creates a reasonable apprehension of bias in a decision held in trust for others.
- **B.** No ethical issue arises, because ethical assessment begins only after a rule has been breached.
- **C.** The conduct is unethical only if the officer subjectively feels influenced by the hospitality.
- **D.** The conduct is automatically criminal because any hospitality from a bidder is an illegal gratification.

Answer: A

Option-by-option explanation

- **A - correct.** Legality, morality and propriety are separate tests. Propriety asks what the office and occasion make appropriate, and its remedies are disclosure, recusal and avoidance rather than punishment.
- **B - wrong.** This is the equation that ARC Box 2.3 exists to reject, quoting the warning that "morality has become identical with legality" in public life.
- **C - wrong.** The public test is not the officer's private feeling but whether a reasonable citizen who lost the contract could regard the decision as impartial. Subjective confidence is unverifiable.
- **D - wrong.** Criminality requires the elements of the relevant offence to be made out. Asserting automatic criminality both overstates the law and, by making the bar impossibly high, would in practice acquit most improper conduct.

Trap: The stem deliberately removes both payment and rule-breach so that the only available failure is propriety. Candidates who look for a bribe find none and wrongly conclude that nothing is wrong.

MCQ 10

Box 2.3 of the Second ARC's Fourth Report quotes a warning about public integrity. Which statement correctly identifies both its content and its cited source?

- **A.** It quotes Mahatma Gandhi on remaking ourselves, drawn from the Report's Preface.
- **B.** It quotes Senator Fulbright on favours accepted "under the guise of friendship" that "offend the spirit of the law but do not violate its letter", and on morality having "become identical with legality", sourced to the Senate Ethics Manual, 2003 edition.
- **C.** It quotes Aleksandr Solzhenitsyn on the line between good and evil passing through every human heart.
- **D.** It reproduces the Nolan Committee's seven principles of public life in full - selflessness, integrity, objectivity, accountability, openness, honesty and leadership - and presents them as the model code that the Commission recommends for adoption by every organ of government in India.

Answer: B

Option-by-option explanation

- **A - wrong.** The Gandhi passage on remaking ourselves does appear in the Report, but in the Preface, not in Box 2.3, and it makes no claim about the letter and spirit of law.
- **B - correct.** Box 2.3, "Need for Ethical Code", reproduces Senator Fulbright's questions about those who "under the guise of friendship, accept favours, which offend the spirit of the law but do not violate its letter", and his warning that "among so many influential people, morality has become identical with legality". The cited source is the Senate Ethics Manual, 2003 edition, page 6.
- **C - wrong.** The Solzhenitsyn line about the line between good and evil is quoted in the Report's Preface, in a different argument about the limits of rules.
- **D - wrong.** The Nolan principles appear in the surrounding text of the same chapter, not inside Box 2.3, and they are owned by Topic 09 rather than by this legality-versus-propriety argument.

Trap: Several memorable quotations sit close together in the Report. Anchor Box 2.3 by its subject - the letter-versus-spirit gap - rather than by a general impression that it is "the famous ethics box".

MCQ 11

Which statement most accurately reproduces the Second ARC's account of how incentives shape the conduct of ordinary people?

- **A.** Individuals with strong values are unaffected by the pattern of rewards and punishments around them, because the Commission treats character as an independent variable formed entirely in the family and in early education, and therefore already fixed by the time an officer enters public service.
- **B.** Corruption is best explained by the personality traits of a small deviant minority acting alone.
- **C.** Where good behaviour is not rewarded but is "fraught with difficulties", and bad behaviour is not punished but is "often extravagantly rewarded", "the bulk of the people tend to stray from the honourable path".
- **D.** Punishment alone determines conduct, and reward structures are ethically irrelevant.

Answer: C

Option-by-option explanation

- **A - wrong.** The report's argument runs the other way: incentives matter for everyone and are "critical in dealing with the army of public servants - elected or appointed".
- **B - wrong.** The deviant-minority account is one of two approaches the ARC *describes* at 1.4 and then declines to adopt on its own at 1.5.
- **C - correct.** This is ARC 1.4's conditional in the report's own words, and it is the sentence that carries the incentive argument into the values-and-institutions synthesis of 1.5.
- **D - wrong.** The same passage gives reward and punishment equal weight - "good behaviour is consistently rewarded and bad behaviour consistently punished" - so treating reward as irrelevant halves the mechanism.

Trap: The passage is often remembered only in its punitive half. The examinable proposition is symmetric: unrewarded honesty is as corrosive as unpunished dishonesty.

MCQ 12

Which formulation best states the Second ARC's own resolution of the values-versus-institutions debate?

- **A.** Institutions are unnecessary where a society already possesses abundant values.
- **B.** Values are decorative; only enforceable institutional rules produce ethical conduct.
- **C.** Values and institutions are alternatives, and a society with limited administrative and fiscal capacity must choose which of the two to invest in first, the Commission's advice being that value formation should precede institutional redesign wherever a sense of right and wrong is already widespread.
- **D.** Both matter: values serve as guiding stars and exist in abundance, but "values without institutional support will soon be weakened and dissipated", because "institutions provide the container, which gives shape and content to values".

Answer: D

Option-by-option explanation

- **A - wrong.** The report says the opposite: values are abundant *and* perishable, which is exactly why institutional containment is required.
- **B - wrong.** ARC 1.5 insists values are "needed to serve as guiding stars"; dismissing them as decorative contradicts the first half of the paragraph.
- **C - wrong.** The paragraph opens with "In the real world, both values and institutions matter", which forecloses any either/or framing.
- **D - correct.** It reproduces both halves of ARC 1.5, including the container metaphor that the Commission calls "the basis of all statecraft and laws and institutions".

Trap: The container metaphor is frequently misquoted as values containing institutions. The direction matters: institutions are the container; values are what is contained.

MCQ 13

Which set correctly names the three factors by which, according to the Second ARC, corruption and abuse of office have been *aggravated* in Indian society?

- **A.** A colonial legacy of unchallenged authority; an enormous asymmetry of power; and an early post-Independence policy regime of over-regulation and scarcity.
- **B.** Illiteracy; linguistic diversity; and federal division of powers.
- **C.** Judicial delay in the disposal of corruption trials; a media unable to sustain investigative reporting; and low public expenditure on education, which together are identified in Chapter 1 as the three factors that have most aggravated corruption and abuse of office in Indian society.
- **D.** Population growth; urbanisation; and the absence of a written code of conduct.

Answer: A

Option-by-option explanation

- **A - correct.** ARC 1.6 names the colonial legacy of "unchallenged authority and propensity to exercise power arbitrarily" and the "enormous asymmetry of power", and ARC 1.7 adds the early-decades policy choice of over-regulation, excessive state control, near-monopoly and an economy of scarcity.
- **B - wrong.** None of these three appears in the report's aggravator list. Illiteracy figures only as background to the asymmetry argument, not as an independent aggravator.
- **C - wrong.** Judicial delay and weak enforcement are treated elsewhere in the report as failures of the anti-corruption machinery, not as the three aggravating factors identified in Chapter 1.
- **D - wrong.** The absence of a code is not the diagnosis; ARC 1.1 has already said that codes alone do not ensure ethical behaviour, so this option contradicts the report's opening argument.

Trap: Plausible-sounding governance problems are inserted as distractors. The examinable list is fixed and short - colonial legacy, asymmetry of power, over-regulation and scarcity - and comes from two consecutive paragraphs.

MCQ 14

Consider the following statement: "Nearly 90% of our people are in the unorganized sector, and nearly 70% of the organized workers with job security and a regular monthly wage are employed by the state directly or through public sector undertakings." How should a candidate use this in an answer?

- **A.** As current labour-force data, since it appears in an official Government of India report.
- **B.** As the Second ARC's 2007 illustrative framing of the asymmetry of power, cited with its year and paired with current verified data for any present-day claim.
- **C.** As a projection of future employment patterns endorsed by the Commission.
- **D.** As evidence that public employment should be reduced.

Answer: B

Option-by-option explanation

- **A - wrong.** Official publication does not make a figure current. The percentages are illustrative and belong to the report's January 2007 vantage point.
- **B - correct.** The figures support ARC 1.6's mechanism - that asymmetry "reduces societal pressure to conform to ethical behaviour" - and must be cited with their date, with current data supplied separately for any contemporary claim.
- **C - wrong.** The report makes no projection at all here; it describes a contemporary imbalance to explain why citizens lacked leverage.

- **D - wrong.** The ARC draws no such policy conclusion from the figures. Its inference is about societal pressure and bargaining power, not about the size of public employment.

Trap: Quoting the percentages without the year is one of the most reliable ways to lose credibility in an otherwise good answer. The safe formulation is "the ARC's 2007 illustrative framing".

MCQ 15

Which statement most accurately reproduces the Second ARC's account of the effect of early post-Independence policy choices on the citizen-official relationship?

- **A.** Subsidies and beneficiary programmes eliminated the citizen's dependence on official discretion.
- **B.** The policies were adopted with the deliberate intention of enriching public servants and of creating a permanent class of intermediaries, and the Commission accordingly describes the licensing regime of the early decades as a designed rather than an accidental source of rent, recommending that responsibility be fixed for that choice.
- **C.** Over-regulation, excessive state control and a scarcity economy, combined with subsidies under conditions of power asymmetry, "converted the public servant into patron and master and reduced most citizens into mendicants", raising corruption opportunities and reducing the citizen's "capacity to resist extortionary demands".
- **D.** The policies had no measurable effect on corruption because corruption is determined solely by individual character.

Answer: C

Option-by-option explanation

- **A - wrong.** ARC 1.7 says the opposite: under power asymmetry, subsidies and beneficiary programmes *increased* the citizen's dependence.
- **B - wrong.** The report is explicit that the consequence was "unintended". Imputing corrupt intent to the policy choice misrepresents the source and weakens an answer's credibility.
- **C - correct.** This reproduces ARC 1.7's mechanism, including its two-sided effect on opportunity and on the citizen's capacity to resist.
- **D - wrong.** A character-only account is one of the two approaches the ARC sets out at 1.4 and declines to adopt alone at 1.5; the whole of 1.7 is a structural explanation.

Trap: "Unintended consequence" is the phrase that keeps this answer accurate. Candidates who dramatise the passage into a charge of deliberate design cross from analysis into assertion.

MCQ 16

Which set of sectors does the Second ARC name as having seen enhanced supply and choice after economic liberalisation, with corruption "reducing or even eliminating"?

- A. Coal, petroleum, fertiliser and irrigation
- B. Banking, insurance, pharmaceuticals and shipping
- C. Land records, policing, taxation and municipal licensing
- D. Telephones, steel, cement, sugar and two-wheelers

Answer: D

Option-by-option explanation

- **A - wrong.** These are administered or licence-heavy sectors that the report does not cite as liberalisation successes; several of them illustrate the opposite, where discretion persisted.
- **B - wrong.** Although liberalised, these sectors are not the ones named in ARC 1.8. Inventing a plausible list is the commonest way this question is lost.
- **C - wrong.** These are precisely the natural-monopoly and discretionary domains to which ARC 1.12 warns corruption migrates, not the sectors where it fell.
- **D - correct.** ARC 1.8 names "Telephones, steel, cement, sugar and even two-wheelers", and separately cites railway reservation and driving licences as services improved by computerisation and access to information.

Trap: Sugar and two-wheelers are the two items candidates drop. Reproducing the complete five-item list, plus the two computerised services, is what separates a sourced answer from a remembered one.

MCQ 17

Which statement best captures the Second ARC's argument about over-centralisation?

- A. The more remotely power is exercised from the people, the greater the distance between authority and accountability, with many functionaries between the citizen and the final decision-maker diffusing accountability; India, the report adds, "probably has the smallest number of final decision makers" for a large democracy.
- B. Centralisation improves ethics because senior officers are less exposed to local pressure.
- C. The report treats centralisation as ethically neutral, observing that a compact decision-making structure shortens files and reduces the number of officials able to extract a payment, and it therefore confines its criticism in this chapter to the demand for illegitimate funds generated by political competition.
- D. Over-centralisation is a problem only in federal systems with weak state governments.

Answer: A

Option-by-option explanation

- **A - correct.** This reproduces ARC 1.9, including the observation about the smallest number of final decision makers, the failure of local government "to take root", and the net result of "weakened citizenry and mounting corruption".
- **B - wrong.** The report records no such protective effect. Distance from local pressure is offset by distance from accountability, which is the paragraph's actual finding.
- **C - wrong.** Political funding is the separate argument of ARC 1.12. Paragraph 1.9 is an explicit criticism of centralisation as a corruption-increasing factor.
- **D - wrong.** The argument is about the distance between power and people, not about federal structure. The report criticises concentration "both horizontally and vertically".

Trap: The phrase "smallest number of final decision makers" sounds like praise for efficiency. In context it is a criticism: too few decision points for too large a democracy, with too many intermediaries in between.

MCQ 18

The Second ARC names several instruments of accountability that "dramatically curbed corruption and promoted integrity and quality of decision making". Which option lists them most completely?

- **A.** Right to Information and social auditing only.
- **B.** Right to Information; effective citizens' charters; opportunity and incentives for a proactive citizenry; stakeholders' involvement in the delivery of public services; public consultation in decision-making; and social auditing.
- **C.** Lokpal, Lokayukta, the Central Vigilance Commission and departmental vigilance officers.
- **D.** Judicial review of administrative action, parliamentary questions and debates, and the Comptroller and Auditor General's statutory audit of receipts and expenditure, which the Commission identifies as the instruments through which citizens hold those in authority to account in a parliamentary democracy.

Answer: B

Option-by-option explanation

- **A - wrong.** It names two of six. The four omitted instruments - charters, proactive-citizen incentives, stakeholder involvement and public consultation - each correct a different component of the asymmetry.
- **B - correct.** This is ARC 1.10's complete list, in the order the paragraph gives it, and the paragraph's own verdict is that these instruments "dramatically curbed corruption".
- **C - wrong.** These are anti-corruption *institutions*, owned by Topic 20, not the citizen-empowerment instruments named at 1.10.
- **D - wrong.** These are constitutional and parliamentary oversight mechanisms. They are accountability instruments in a general sense, but they are not the citizen-empowerment set the paragraph enumerates.

Trap: The question rewards completeness. Because RTI is the most familiar item, partial-list options are chosen far more often than they should be; count the instruments before answering.

MCQ 19

Which statement most accurately reflects the Second ARC's position on prevention and punishment?

- **A.** Preventive systemic reform makes deterrent punishment unnecessary once discretion has been reduced, because an office that has been automated and made transparent leaves no opportunity for extraction, and the Commission accordingly recommends that disciplinary machinery be wound down as e-governance spreads.
- **B.** Punishment is the only reliable instrument, and preventive redesign is a distraction.
- **C.** Enforcement of the rule of law and deterrent punishment are critical to build an ethically sound society, and the report simultaneously demands "a detailed analysis of our anti-corruption mechanisms and the causes of their failure".
- **D.** The report recommends replacing disciplinary proceedings with ethics training.

Answer: C

Option-by-option explanation

- **A - wrong.** ARC 1.11 states that enforcement and deterrent punishment "are critical", so prevention cannot render them unnecessary. The corrective is preventive **and** punitive.
- **B - wrong.** The report's entire structural diagnosis at 1.6-1.10 is preventive. Treating prevention as a distraction contradicts the majority of the chapter.
- **C - correct.** It combines the two halves of ARC 1.11: the necessity of enforcement, and the self-critical demand that the failure of existing machinery itself be analysed before strengthening it.
- **D - wrong.** No such substitution is recommended anywhere in Chapter 1; ARC 1.1 in fact requires "competent disciplinary bodies" that act quickly.

Trap: Options A and B are the two symmetrical extremes, and both are set because candidates who have absorbed the structural argument over-correct into "prevention is enough". Quote both halves of 1.11 and neither extreme is tempting.

MCQ 20

According to the Second ARC, what happens when competition and decentralisation reduce corruption in some sectors while the demand for illegitimate funds in politics persists?

- **A.** Corruption disappears, because supply-side reform eliminates the opportunity for rent-seeking.
- **B.** Corruption is unaffected, because political funding operates independently of administrative processes.
- **C.** Corruption declines uniformly across all sectors at a slower rate.
- **D.** Other avenues "will be forcibly opened up", so that corruption shifts to other, sometimes more dangerous, areas in which competition cannot be introduced and the state exercises a natural monopoly.

Answer: D

Option-by-option explanation

- **A - wrong.** ARC 1.12 expressly denies this: reducing opportunity in one sector does not reduce demand, and unmet demand relocates rather than evaporates.
- **B - wrong.** The paragraph's whole argument is that political demand drives administrative supply, so independence between the two is exactly what the report rejects.
- **C - wrong.** The predicted pattern is not uniform decline but redistribution, with some sectors improving while others deteriorate.
- **D - correct.** This is ARC 1.12's migration finding, and it is why the report calls for "corresponding political and governance reform" alongside liberalisation.

Trap: This is the qualification that converts a good answer into a graded one. Candidates who have just learned ARC 1.8's liberalisation success are precisely the ones most likely to pick option A.

MCQ 21

A widow's sanctioned pension is withheld by a clerk until a payment is made. Which classification and remedy pairing is correct?

- **A.** Coercive corruption, in which the citizen is an unwilling victim of extortion for an entitled service; the matched remedies are a time-bound service guarantee, published fees, an escalation route and protection of the complainant.
- **B.** Collusive corruption, because a payment has passed between a private person and a public servant, the Commission's test for collusion being simply whether money changed hands outside the sanctioned fee, irrespective of whether the payer sought an entitlement or an irregular advantage.
- **C.** Neither category applies, because no contract or procurement is involved.
- **D.** Collusive corruption, because the citizen has voluntarily paid and is therefore an accomplice.

Answer: A

Option-by-option explanation

- **A - correct.** ARC 1.13 defines coercive corruption as extraction for a service to which the citizen is entitled and calls the payer "an unwilling victim"; the remedies follow from the fact that the victim has both an interest and a motive to complain.
- **B - wrong.** The passing of money does not by itself make a transaction collusive. Collusion requires that both parties gain at society's cost, which is absent where the payer receives only what she was already owed.
- **C - wrong.** ARC 1.13 places the "vast majority of cases of bribery" in the coercive category and does not confine corruption to contracts or procurement.

- **D - wrong.** Voluntariness in the formal sense is not the test; the report explains that citizens pay because resistance costs them "much more", which is coercion, not complicity.

Trap: The presence of a payment invites automatic classification as collusion. Classify by *who gains*: if the payer gets only her entitlement, the transaction is extortion.

MCQ 22

Which statement correctly combines the Second ARC's examples of collusive corruption with its stated trend?

- **A.** Collusive corruption is confined to public procurement and declines as the economy is liberalised.
- **B.** Collusive corruption includes awarding of contracts for public works, procurement of goods and services, recruitment of employees, evasion of taxes, substandard projects, collusive violation of regulations, adulteration of foods and drugs, obstruction of justice and doctoring of evidence; and as the economy is freed from state controls, extortionary corruption declines while collusive corruption tends to increase.
- **C.** Collusive corruption always produces a complainant, which makes it easier to detect than extortion.
- **D.** Collusive and coercive corruption are legally and ethically identical and require the same remedy.

Answer: B

Option-by-option explanation

- **A - wrong.** Both halves fail: the report's example list extends well beyond procurement, and its stated trend is that collusive corruption *increases* with liberalisation.
- **B - correct.** It reproduces ARC 1.13's full example list and its trend statement, together with the report's warning that collusive corruption is "undermining the very foundations of our democracy".
- **C - wrong.** The defining feature of collusion is that both parties benefit, which removes the complainant and makes detection harder, not easier.
- **D - wrong.** The report distinguishes them precisely because they are not identical; the victim, the evidence problem and the remedy all differ.

Trap: The long option is correct here, which is why option-length heuristics fail on this item. Verify against the source list rather than against option length.

MCQ 23

Which of the following did the Second ARC's Fourth Report identify at paragraph 1.16 as still needing to be done, "beyond the realm of existing regulation"?

1. Forfeiture of benami properties of corrupt public servants and of assets illegally acquired from corrupt practices.
 2. Whistleblower legislation to protect informants against retribution.
 3. Strengthening the institutional framework for investigating corrupt practices and awarding exemplary punishment.
- **A.** 1 and 2 only
 - **B.** 2 and 3 only
 - **C.** 1, 2 and 3
 - **D.** 3 only

Answer: C

Option-by-option explanation

- **A - wrong.** It omits the strengthening of the investigative framework and exemplary punishment, which the paragraph explicitly links to "raising the risk associated with corrupt behaviour".
- **B - wrong.** It omits forfeiture, which the paragraph names first in the context of black money, serious economic offences, fraud and money laundering.
- **C - correct.** All three appear in ARC 1.16, and all three are stated as things that "need to be" or "have to be" done - that is, as recommendations of January 2007, not as existing law at that date.

- **D - wrong.** Reducing the paragraph to enforcement alone discards its asset-recovery and whistleblower-protection components.

Trap: The status word is the examinable point. These were recommendations in 2007; later statutory developments belong to Topics 19 and 21 and must be dated separately rather than credited to the report.

MCQ 24

Which statement most accurately reflects the Second ARC's view of the scope of ethics beyond government?

- **A.** Ethics in governance is confined to the conduct of public servants, since private conduct lies outside the state's concern.
- **B.** Citizen behaviour is expressly excluded from the report's scope, because the Commission classifies the citizen at paragraph 1.13 as an unwilling victim of extortion and therefore confines its ethical demands to public servants, elected representatives, regulators and the corporate entities that transact with government, leaving ordinary citizens to the general criminal law alone.
- **C.** The report recommends that ethical standards be applied to business alone, because commercial actors are the principal source of bribes.
- **D.** Ethics in governance "has a much wider import" and an across-the-board effort must include corporate ethics and a shift from "business ethics" to "ethics in business", ethics in every profession, voluntary organisation and civil society structure, and ethics in citizen behaviour, which "impinges directly on ethics in government and administration".

Answer: D

Option-by-option explanation

- **A - wrong.** ARC 1.17 opens by rejecting exactly this confinement: ethics in governance "has a much wider import than what happens in the different arms of the government".
- **B - wrong.** The paragraph does the opposite: it ends by insisting that "there should be ethics in citizen behaviour". The victim framing at 1.13 applies to coerced payers, not to the citizen's role generally.
- **C - wrong.** Business is one of four named domains. Professions, voluntary organisations and civil society structures, and citizen behaviour, are the other three.
- **D - correct.** It reproduces ARC 1.17 in full, including the demanded "paradigm shift from the pejorative 'business ethics' to 'ethics in business'" and the closing clause on citizen behaviour.

Trap: ARC 1.13's "unwilling victim" and ARC 1.17's citizen duty sit four paragraphs apart and appear to conflict. They do not: coercion excuses the extorted payer, while 1.17 addresses the citizen's general ethical role, including collusive conduct.

REMEDIAL DRILLS 25-32

Each remedial drill targets one predictable error recorded in the learning session's trap boxes.

MCQ 25

Targets the error: "ethics and morality are always technically identical."

Which statement gives the most precise distinction available on demand?

- **A. Ethics** is the systematic, reasoned examination of standards of right conduct, while morality denotes the beliefs and practices actually held by persons or communities; the terms overlap in ordinary usage but must be separated when a claim is being critically assessed.
- **B. Ethics** applies to public life and morality applies only to private life.
- **C. Ethics** is codified in law, whereas morality is never written down.
- **D. Morality** is superior to ethics because it is derived from religious and community teaching tested over centuries, whereas ethics is a modern academic construction that produces argument without obligation and therefore cannot bind an officer who remains unpersuaded by the reasoning offered.

Answer: A

Option-by-option explanation

- **A - correct.** The distinction is between a reasoned standard and a held practice. It is available on demand without denying that the words are used interchangeably in ordinary Mains prose.
- **B - wrong.** Both terms operate in both domains. A private promise raises an ethical question; a public office raises moral ones. The public/private line is a different distinction, addressed in the private-versus-public relationships session.
- **C - wrong.** Ethics is not defined by codification. Codes of ethics exist, but so do unwritten ethical standards, and much morality is in fact written down in religious and community codes.
- **D - wrong.** Ranking the two is not a distinction, and grounding morality solely in religion ignores its social, familial and professional sources.

Trap: The error is over-correction. Having learned that the terms differ, candidates then deny that they ever overlap, which produces an equally inaccurate answer.

MCQ 26

Targets the error: "the Second ARC blamed declining values for corruption."

Which reading of the report is accurate?

- **A.** The report endorses the decline-of-values explanation and treats institutional reform as secondary.
- **B.** The report sets out the decline-of-values and deviant-minority explanations as two "somewhat contrary" approaches and adopts neither alone, holding that "in the real world, both values and institutions matter".
- **C.** The report rejects values entirely and treats corruption as purely a design problem.
- **D.** The report treats the two explanations as identical restatements of a single theory.

Answer: B

Option-by-option explanation

- **A - wrong.** The decline-of-values position is described at 1.4 as an "overemphasis on values and character"; the word "overemphasis" is the report's own evaluation.
- **B - correct.** ARC 1.4 presents both approaches and 1.5 supplies the synthesis, including the guiding-stars and container formulations.
- **C - wrong.** ARC 1.5 states that values "are needed to serve as guiding stars" and "exist in abundance in our society", which is the opposite of rejection.
- **D - wrong.** The report calls them "two, somewhat contrary, approaches"; one locates the cause in character, the other in a deviant minority requiring deterrence.

Trap: Chapter 1 spends more words describing the two approaches than stating the synthesis, so a skim leaves the impression that the report endorses whichever approach was read last.

MCQ 27

Targets the error: "all corruption is the citizen's fault for paying a bribe."

Which statement is most consistent with the Second ARC's analysis?

- **A.** Every bribe-payer is equally culpable, because payment is always voluntary in the sense that the citizen could have refused, complained to a vigilance authority or approached a court, and the Commission accordingly treats the giving and the taking of a bribe as ethically symmetrical wherever there was no physical compulsion.
- **B.** The citizen's culpability depends only on the amount paid.
- **C.** In the vast majority of bribery cases the citizen is a victim of extortion compelled to pay for an entitled service, and the report notes that citizens "often end up losing much more by resisting corruption"; culpability attaches with full force in collusive cases, where both parties gain.
- **D.** Citizens are never culpable in any corruption transaction.

Answer: C

Option-by-option explanation

- **A - wrong.** ARC 1.13 explicitly describes the extorted payer as "an unwilling victim", and lists the costs of resistance - delay, harassment, lost wages, even danger to life or limb - that make formal voluntariness meaningless.
- **B - wrong.** The amount is irrelevant to the classification. What matters is whether the payer received an entitlement or an irregular advantage.
- **C - correct.** It preserves both halves of the report: protection for the coerced, and full culpability in collusion, where "both parties benefit at immense cost to society".
- **D - wrong.** This over-corrects. ARC 1.13's collusive category and 1.17's demand for "ethics in citizen behaviour" both make citizens duty-bearers.

Trap: The two errors are symmetrical - blaming every payer, or exonerating every payer. The classification test is *who gains*, and it must be applied transaction by transaction.

MCQ 28

Targets the error: "if an act is legal, no ethical question arises."

Which response is best supported by the Second ARC's own material?

- **A.** Legality settles the matter, because public servants can only fairly be judged by enforceable rules published in advance, and any additional standard of propriety would expose an officer to censure for conduct that no provision prohibited at the time it occurred, which is itself unfair.
- **B.** Ethics and legality diverge only in private life, never in official decisions.
- **C.** Ethical evaluation applies only where a court has already found a violation.
- **D.** Legality, morality and propriety are three separate tests; ARC Box 2.3 quotes the warning that "morality has become identical with legality" precisely in order to reject that equation, and describes favours that "offend the spirit of the law but do not violate its letter".

Answer: D

Option-by-option explanation

- **A - wrong.** This is the very position Box 2.3 was included to criticise, and it is described there as a "tragic plight" for public life.
- **B - wrong.** The Fulbright passage concerns public officials and official favours, so the divergence is illustrated in official life, not excluded from it.
- **C - wrong.** Making judicial finding a precondition would postpone ethical evaluation until after litigation, which is both impractical and contrary to the preventive logic of the whole report.
- **D - correct.** It states the three-test separation and supplies the report's own authority for it, with the letter-versus-spirit formulation.

Trap: Candidates who know the three tests still choose a legality-first option when the stem describes conduct that is clearly lawful. The correct move is to name propriety as the failing test and prescribe disclosure or recusal.

MCQ 29

Targets the paired errors: "liberalisation is unrelated to ethics" and "liberalisation ended corruption."

Which statement holds both halves of the Second ARC's position together?

- **A.** Competition, choice and transparency demonstrably reduced corruption in named sectors after liberalisation, but where demand for illegitimate funds persists, corruption migrates to natural-monopoly sectors rather than disappearing.
- **B.** Liberalisation is an economic policy with no ethical consequences whatever.
- **C.** Liberalisation eliminated corruption in India across all sectors.
- **D.** Liberalisation increased corruption everywhere by weakening state supervision.

Answer: A

Option-by-option explanation

- **A - correct.** It joins ARC 1.8's sectoral finding to ARC 1.12's migration warning, which is exactly the balanced position the report holds.
- **B - wrong.** ARC 1.8 attributes a measurable fall in corruption to competition and choice, so denying any ethical consequence contradicts the report directly.
- **C - wrong.** ARC 1.12 states that corruption "shifts to other, sometimes more dangerous, areas", which forecloses any claim of elimination.
- **D - wrong.** The report records reductions, not universal increases. It does warn of new risks, but as relocation rather than as an across-the-board rise.

Trap: The two errors sit on opposite sides, and a candidate correcting one usually falls into the other. Write both sentences - the sectoral gain and the migration caveat - in that order.

MCQ 30

Targets the error: "decentralisation always reduces corruption."

Which qualification is best supported?

- **A.** Decentralisation is ethically neutral and has no effect on the citizen-official interface.
- **B.** Decentralisation shortens the distance between authority and accountability, but without matching capacity, transparency and audit it can create many small local monopolies of discretion in place of one large one.
- **C.** Decentralisation guarantees accountability because local officials are personally known to the citizens they serve, are answerable at village or ward meetings, and can be confronted immediately about a delayed file, which removes the anonymity on which extraction at a distant office depends.
- **D.** Decentralisation is undesirable because it multiplies the number of decision-makers.

Answer: B

Option-by-option explanation

- **A - wrong.** ARC 1.9 treats over-centralisation as a corruption-increasing factor, so proximity of power is not ethically neutral.
- **B - correct.** It preserves the benefit the report identifies while adding the capacity, transparency and audit conditions without which local discretion simply replaces central discretion.
- **C - wrong.** Personal acquaintance can as easily produce local capture and pressure as accountability; familiarity is not a substitute for a record and a review route.
- **D - wrong.** ARC 1.9 in fact criticises India for having "probably the smallest number of final decision makers" for a large democracy, so multiplying decision points is not itself the problem.

Trap: Distance and accountability are two different variables. Decentralisation reliably reduces the first; it improves the second only when capacity, transparency and audit accompany it.

MCQ 31

Targets the error: citing the Second ARC's 2007 illustrative percentages as current data.

An answer written today needs to establish that unequal bargaining power still weakens ethical accountability at the counter. What is the correct evidentiary practice?

- **A.** Quote the 90% and 70% figures as current statistics, since they come from an official commission.
- **B.** Omit the asymmetry argument altogether, because its supporting figures are dated.
- **C.** State the ARC's mechanism with its 2007 date, and support any present-day quantitative claim with a current, independently verified source such as the latest Economic Survey's formalisation data.
- **D.** Update the figures yourself to plausible current values so that the argument reads as contemporary.

Answer: C

Option-by-option explanation

- **A - wrong.** Official provenance does not confer currency. The percentages are the report's illustrative framing of January 2007.
- **B - wrong.** The mechanism - that asymmetry "reduces societal pressure to conform to ethical behaviour" - remains valid and is the analytically valuable part; discarding it loses a diagnosed cause.
- **C - correct.** Date the report's claim, keep the mechanism, and attach current verified data for any contemporary quantitative assertion.
- **D - wrong.** Adjusting figures without a source is fabrication, which is the single most damaging thing a candidate can do in a sourced answer.

Trap: The temptation is to keep a memorable number at the cost of accuracy. The mechanism, not the percentage, is what earns the mark.

MCQ 32

Targets the error: treating Comprehensive National Power as a synonym for military strength.

Which framing is most defensible in a GS-IV answer?

- **A.** Comprehensive National Power is military capability measured by force levels, platforms and strategic reach, to which ethical considerations are largely irrelevant because the deterrent value of an armed force depends on its demonstrated capacity rather than on the integrity of the procedures by which it was equipped.
- **B.** Comprehensive National Power is economic output, and ethics affects it only through tax compliance.
- **C.** Ethics contributes to Comprehensive National Power only by improving a country's international image.
- **D.** Comprehensive National Power is composite - economic, military or strategic, socio-cultural or soft, technological and diplomatic - and ethics acts as a credibility multiplier on each component, with social harmony as the component to which it contributes most directly.

Answer: D

Option-by-option explanation

- **A - wrong.** It collapses a composite concept into one component and then removes the ethical dimension that procurement integrity and civil-military trust supply even within that component.
- **B - wrong.** Reducing the ethical channel to tax compliance ignores contract enforcement, predictability and non-expropriation, which the report's own Preface links to growth.
- **C - wrong.** Image is a consequence, not the mechanism. The mechanism runs through predictability, procurement quality, research integrity and honoured commitments.
- **D - correct.** It names the five components and states the multiplier thesis, while preserving the honest limitation that ethics does not substitute for material capacity.

Trap: The question rewards a mechanism per component. An answer that lists the components without saying *how* ethics strengthens each reads as a definition rather than as an argument.

ANSWER KEY AND ROTATION AUDIT

Q	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15	16
Key	A	B	C	D	A	B	C	D	A	B	C	D	A	B	C	D

Q	17	18	19	20	21	22	23	24	25	26	27	28	29	30	31	32
Key	A	B	C	D	A	B	C	D	A	B	C	D	A	B	C	D

Rotation string: ABCDABCDABCDABCDABCDABCDABCDABCD - 32 questions, 8 of each option, strict A -> B -> C -> D repeated eight times.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

OWNERSHIP AND VERIFICATION LEDGER

Item	Year / paper	Verification status	Routing ownership	Treatment here
PYQ-1	2024 GS-IV Q1(b)	FACT: Verbatim English wording read directly from books\ mains\ 05 UPSC 2024 Paper- IV_ Final 1.pdf, page 2, including the printed form decision&making	FACT: Directly owned by Ethics Topic 01 together with Topic 13 for Q1(a) - _ PYQ- ROUTING- MAINS- GS3- GS4- 2024- 2025.md	Fully solved at exam length
PYQ-2	2025 GS-IV Q1(b)	FACT: Verbatim English wording read directly from books\ mains\ UPSC Mains 2025 GS Paper 4.pdf, page 2, including the printed spelling adherence	ANALYSIS: Routed to Topic 13 and Topic 14 , not to Topic 01. Retained here as a <i>cross-topic anchor</i> because the values-plus-institutions synthesis of ARC 1.5 is its analytical spine	Fully solved, ownership stated
RD-1	2020 GS-IV Q1(a)	ANALYSIS: Neutral routed demand. The 2020 paper is not held locally , so no verbatim claim is made	FACT: Routed to Ethics Topic 01 and Topic 02	Solved from the neutral demand
RD-2	2020 GS-IV Q1(b)	ANALYSIS: Neutral routed demand; paper not held locally	FACT: Routed to Ethics Topic 01 and Topic 02, with Topic 02 primary	Solved from the neutral demand
RD-3	2020 GS-IV Q2(a)	ANALYSIS: Neutral routed demand; paper not held locally	FACT: Routed to Ethics Topic 01 and Topic 05	Solved from the neutral demand
RD-4	2022 GS-IV Q2(a)	ANALYSIS: Neutral routed demand; paper not held locally	FACT: Routed to Topic 03 (primary) and Topic 01	Solved from the neutral demand
RD-5	2022 GS-IV Q2(b)	ANALYSIS: Neutral routed demand; paper not held locally	FACT: Routed to Topic 03 and Topic 01	Solved from the neutral demand

Verified marks contract for GS-IV, read directly from both locally held official papers. Every Section-A sub-question in the 2024 and 2025 GS-IV papers carries "(Answer in 150 words)" for 10 marks; every Section-B case study carries "(Answer in 250 words)" for 20 marks. **GS-IV contains no 15-mark question.** The 15-mark items in the original-practice set below are therefore retained as deliberately labelled *extended analytical practice* - they satisfy the repository's 10/15/20 practice requirement and build depth, but they are not a GS-IV paper format and must not be mistaken for one.

Solved PYQ 1 - 2024 GS-IV, Q1(b) - 10 marks - 150 words - directly owned

Question (verbatim official English wording): "Ethics encompasses several key dimensions that are crucial in guiding individuals and organizations towards morally responsible behaviour." Explain the key dimensions of ethics that influence human actions. Discuss how these dimensions shape ethical decision-making in the professional context.

Source note: exact English text from the locally held official PDF books\mains\05 UPSC 2024 Paper-IV_Final 1.pdf, question 1(b), page 2. The printed source itself carries decision-making; the artefact is preserved rather than silently corrected.

Demand decoding. Two directives, therefore two obligations. **Explain** requires the dimensions to be named and defined as *respects of evaluation*, not as a list of virtues. **Discuss** requires movement from taxonomy to a named professional setting, showing how the dimensions operate on an actual decision. An answer that stops after the list forfeits roughly half the marks whatever its quality.

Model answer (exam length - 149 words)

Ethics evaluates action against standards, so its dimensions are the respects in which any decision can be judged. Six carry professional practice: duty and rights, which treat the citizen as an entitlement-holder; consequences, which ask who is harmed and how foreseeably; justice and fairness, which require like cases to be treated alike; virtue, which tests character under pressure; care, which attends to the most vulnerable claimant; and accountability, which demands reasons capable of public scrutiny.

They shape decisions by functioning as mutual checks. A district officer finalising a beneficiary list applies published criteria, hears objections, protects personal data and records reasons for exclusion, thereby satisfying duty, fairness and accountability together. Compassion may prompt help but cannot justify a secret insertion.

No dimension decides alone: rigid rules ignore hardship, outcome-only reasoning rationalises unfair means, and care without fairness becomes favouritism. Sound professional judgment names the conflict and justifies the trade-off.

Why this earns marks. It defines "dimensions" correctly, supplies all six, converts them into a named Indian administrative act, and closes with the plural-checks verdict that answers the second directive.

Expansion bank (not part of the timed answer). If the question is set at greater length, add: the four levels of ethical enquiry as the prior classification, with the is-ought caution; the ARC 1.1 point that standards require adoption in action, sanctions and competent disciplinary machinery; and the observation that personal good intention cannot cure a biased procedure or an unreviewable decision.

How to improve a weak attempt. Replace any abstract sentence about "moral values" with one named dimension plus the specific administrative failure it detects, and end with a trade-off rather than with a restatement of the opening.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2025 GS-IV, Q1(b) - 10 marks - 150 words - cross-topic anchor

Question (verbatim official English wording): "Constitutional morality is not a natural sentiment but a product of civil education and adherence of the rule of law." Examine the significance of constitutional morality for public servant highlighting the role in promoting good governance and ensuring accountability in public administration.

Source note: exact English text from the locally held official PDF books\mains\UPSC Mains 2025 GS Paper 4.pdf, question 1(b), page 2. The printed source carries adherence; the spelling is preserved.

Ownership note. ANALYSIS: The routing ledger assigns this question to Ethics Topics 13 and 14, and the official syllabus mapping records that "Constitutional morality is Topic 14 primary with Topic 10 as a guidance-source cross-link." It is retained here as a cross-topic anchor, not claimed as Topic 01 property, because its premise - that constitutional morality is *produced* by civil education and rule-of-law practice rather than felt naturally - is exactly the values-plus-institutions synthesis of ARC 1.5.

Demand decoding. Examine requires a position plus its limits. The stem supplies the thesis; the candidate must show *how* constitutional morality operates, and must cover both listed functions - good governance and accountability - with an administrative illustration.

Model answer (exam length - 148 words)

Constitutional morality is disciplined fidelity to constitutional values and lawful procedure rather than to personal preference, majority sentiment or official convenience. Because it is acquired through civic education and rule-of-law practice, it must be converted into daily conduct: equality, dignity, liberty, fair procedure and accountability.

It promotes good governance in three ways. It restrains arbitrary power, since published criteria, hearings and recorded reasons displace discretionary favour. It protects minorities and vulnerable persons when local prejudice is popular. It makes decisions auditable, because the officer can name the value and rule supporting the action. A District Magistrate allocating flood relief must apply transparent need-based criteria across caste, religion and political affiliation, record exclusions and provide grievance review.

It does not require mechanical rule-worship. Exceptional hardship may demand humane discretion, but discretion must stay reasoned, non-discriminatory and reviewable. Constitutional morality is thus the bridge between legal authority and legitimate administration.

Why this earns marks. It accepts the stem's premise, converts it into three named governance mechanisms, supplies an Indian illustration, and qualifies with the discretion caveat instead of ending on a slogan.

Link back to Topic 01. The claim that constitutional morality is "not a natural sentiment" is the ARC's own position in different words: values exist in abundance but are perishable, so institutions must contain them.

Routed Demand 1 - 2020 GS-IV Q1(a) - 10 marks - neutral rendering

Neutral rendering of the routed demand: Discuss the role of ethics and values in enhancing the three major components of Comprehensive National Power and social harmony.

Source / ownership: ANALYSIS: Neutral rendering from _PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS3-GS4-2018-2023.md. The 2020 GS-IV paper is not held locally, so this is **not** presented as official wording. Routed to Ethics Topic 01 and Topic 02.

Demand decoding. Discuss requires the components to be named and then a distinct mechanism supplied for each, ending with the relationship between ethics and material capacity.

Model answer (exam length - 149 words)

Comprehensive National Power is composite: economic, military or strategic, socio-cultural, technological and diplomatic. Ethics and values raise the usable value of each by making capacity credible.

Economically, predictable rules and low graft reduce uncertainty for citizens and investors; the Second ARC's own finding that competition and transparency curbed corruption after liberalisation shows the channel. Strategically, procurement integrity ensures capability is bought on merit rather than commission, and apolitical professionalism keeps the chain of command trusted. Socially, equal respect and constitutional conduct reduce fragmentation, which is the component ethics strengthens most directly. Technologically, research integrity sustains confidence in results; diplomatically, honoured commitments accumulate credibility that force cannot purchase.

Values cannot substitute for industry, defence preparedness or state capacity, and social harmony does not arise from slogans; both need institutional expression through fair law and transparent administration. Ethics is therefore a multiplier of national power, not an ornament attached to it.

Why this earns marks. It refuses the military-only reading, gives five components one mechanism each, and concedes the limit that ethics multiplies rather than replaces material capacity.

Routed Demand 2 - 2020 GS-IV Q1(b) - 10 marks - neutral rendering

Neutral rendering of the routed demand: Examine education as a pervasive tool for individual development and social transformation, with reference to NEP 2020.

Source / ownership: ANALYSIS: Neutral rendering from the 2018-2023 routed-demand ledger; the paper is not held locally. Routed to Ethics Topic 01 and Topic 02, with Topic 02 primary for the value-inculcation limb. Retained here because "civil education" is the individual determinant of ethical conduct taught in this topic.

Demand decoding. Examine requires both the transformative claim and its failure conditions, with the individual and the social level treated separately.

Model answer (exam length - 147 words)

Education is pervasive because it develops capability and simultaneously shapes the habits through which capability is used. It can cultivate reasoning, empathy, scientific temper, constitutional values and respect for diversity.

For the individual, it enlarges informed choice, employability, self-respect and the capacity to question prejudice. For society, it can weaken inherited exclusion, support gender equality and build civic participation. A school that secures girls' attendance, inclusive classroom practice and a working grievance route changes who can later participate in public and economic life; that repeated experience of equal treatment is precisely the civil education through which constitutional morality becomes practicable.

Schooling is not automatically transformative. Poor quality, digital exclusion, segregated access or rote moral instruction can reproduce hierarchy instead of challenging it. Education therefore requires accessible institutions, fair opportunity and accountable implementation. It is a powerful long-term instrument exactly when knowledge, values and equal access are joined.

Why this earns marks. It separates the individual and social levels, names a concrete school-level mechanism, and states the conditions under which education fails to transform.

Routed Demand 3 - 2020 GS-IV Q2(a) - 10 marks - neutral rendering

Neutral rendering of the routed demand: Hatred is destructive of wisdom and conscience - do you agree? Justify your answer.

Source / ownership: ANALYSIS: Neutral rendering from the 2018-2023 routed-demand ledger; the paper is not held locally. Routed to Ethics Topic 01 and Topic 05, with Topic 05 owning the emotional-intelligence limb.

Demand decoding. Do you agree / justify requires an explicit side, defended against the strongest objection rather than merely asserted.

Model answer (exam length - 150 words)

I agree, with one qualification. Hatred is destructive of wisdom because it fixes judgment before evidence: the hating official already knows who is guilty, so contrary facts are discounted and the decision is made by the emotion rather than by the file. It is destructive of conscience because conscience works by imagining the other person's standpoint, which hatred forbids.

In administration the damage is concrete. A supervisor who despises a subordinate community will read the same conduct as negligence in one officer and as misfortune in another, producing unequal discipline that no rule has authorised. Reasoned procedure - recorded grounds, a hearing, review by another authority - exists partly to catch this.

The qualification is that moral anger at cruelty or corruption is not hatred; it is indignation directed at conduct, and can sharpen conscience. The ethical distinction lies in whether the emotion is aimed at an act or at a person.

Why this earns marks. It takes a side, explains two distinct mechanisms of damage, supplies an administrative illustration, and separates hatred from legitimate moral indignation.

Routed Demand 4 - 2022 GS-IV Q2(a) - 10 marks - neutral rendering

Neutral rendering of the routed demand: Explain how a positive and a negative mindset can lead to different interpretations of rules and regulations.

Source / ownership: ANALYSIS: Neutral rendering from the 2018-2023 routed-demand ledger; the paper is not held locally. Routed to Topic 03 (attitude - primary) and Ethics Topic 01. Retained here for its human-interface consequence.

Demand decoding. Explain requires the mechanism by which an attitude changes interpretation, then a case where the two readings diverge in their effect on a citizen.

Model answer (exam length - 147 words)

A mindset decides what an official believes a rule is *for*. A positive mindset treats regulation as an instrument for securing fairness, safety and public trust, so ambiguity is resolved towards the rule's purpose. A negative mindset treats regulation chiefly as an obstacle, a source of leverage or a shield against responsibility, so ambiguity is resolved towards refusal.

The consequence is unequal service from identical rules. Faced with an incomplete application, the first officer identifies the missing document, records a deficiency memo and fixes a date; the second returns the file unexplained, converting a curable defect into a fresh journey for the applicant. Neither has broken a rule.

The qualification is that positivity is not indulgence. Purposive interpretation must stay within the rule's text and be recorded, otherwise discretion becomes personal. The ethical standard is a reading that serves the rule's object and can be stated publicly.

Why this earns marks. It locates the difference in interpretation rather than in compliance, illustrates identical rules producing unequal outcomes, and guards against the "positive attitude means bending rules" misreading.

Routed Demand 5 - 2022 GS-IV Q2(b) - 10 marks - neutral rendering

Neutral rendering of the routed demand: Discuss ethics in human actions and its role in resolving conflicts in everyday functioning.

Source / ownership: ANALYSIS: Neutral rendering from the 2018-2023 routed-demand ledger; the paper is not held locally. Routed to Topic 03 and Ethics Topic 01.

Demand decoding. Discuss requires a working definition of ethics in action, then its specific contribution to conflict resolution, then its limits.

Model answer (exam length - 148 words)

Ethics in human action means choosing conduct that can be justified by standards - honesty, fairness, non-harm, empathy, duty and accountability - rather than by preference or convenience. Everyday conflicts involve not only competing interests but unequal power, incomplete information and questions of respect.

Ethics contributes three things to their resolution. It converts a clash of wills into a comparison of reasons, so the stronger party cannot simply prevail. It identifies whose interest is an entitlement and whose is a preference, which fixes the order of priority. It supplies procedures - hearing, disclosure, recorded reasons, review - that make the outcome acceptable even to the party that loses.

Its limits must be stated. Ethical reasoning cannot settle a dispute where facts are contested, and it cannot substitute for authority where a lawful decision is required. Its function is to make the exercise of authority defensible, not to remove the need for it.

Why this earns marks. It defines ethics in action operationally, gives three named contributions to conflict resolution, and closes with the honest limit that ethics does not replace lawful authority.

Structure of this set. Three 10-mark answers at the verified GS-IV Section-A length of 150 words; two 15-mark extended analytical practice answers, expressly labelled because GS-IV has no 15-mark question; two 20-mark analytical answers at the verified Section-B length of 250 words; and two 20-mark **case studies** in the eight-element GS-IV Section-B architecture owned by Topic 22. Word counts are stated and were verified independently.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Original Mains Practice 1 - 10 marks - 150 words

Question: Distinguish ethics from morality. Why does the distinction matter to a public servant? Answer in about 150 words.

Model answer (147 words)

Ethics is the systematic, reasoned examination of standards of right conduct; morality is the set of beliefs and practices a person or community actually holds. The words overlap in ordinary use, but the distinction matters because a widespread practice is not thereby justified.

For a public servant, morality explains why colleagues treat a festival gift, a political recommendation or preferential treatment as normal. Ethics asks a further question: is the conduct fair, compatible with public duty, non-harmful and publicly defensible? A revenue officer cannot prioritise a relative's mutation file merely because family loyalty is socially valued; public office requires impartiality and equal access.

The distinction must not become contempt for community values, which often reveal genuine hardship and guide humane delivery. But where custom conflicts with constitutional equality or public trust, the officer must reason ethically and act through lawful procedure rather than defer to prevailing belief.

Why this earns marks. It defines both terms, states the practical stake, gives a named administrative example, and qualifies against the opposite error of dismissing community morality altogether.

Original Mains Practice 2 - 10 marks - 150 words

Question: Why is conduct that is legal not necessarily proper in public office? Illustrate. Answer in about 150 words.

Model answer (146 words)

Legality means conformity with enacted law; propriety asks whether conduct suits the responsibilities and the visible standing of the office. The gap matters because rules cannot enumerate every conflict, and public confidence can be lost before any violation is proved.

A district procurement officer may lawfully attend a private dinner hosted by a bidder where no payment or formal favour is established. The event can still create a reasonable apprehension of bias and compromise the officer's independence. The prudent response is disclosure, recusal where the nexus is direct, and avoidance of hospitality a citizen could fairly read as influence. Similar reasoning covers informal meetings, use of official information and public praise for connected firms.

Propriety must not become vague policing of private life; it requires a nexus with office, entrusted power or public perception. Legal compliance is therefore the floor of public conduct, not its ceiling.

Why this earns marks. It separates the two tests, illustrates with a lawful but improper act, prescribes the matching remedy, and guards the boundary against moral policing.

Original Mains Practice 3 - 10 marks - 150 words

Question: "Values without institutional support will soon be weakened and dissipated." Examine this proposition with reference to Indian public administration. Answer in about 150 words.

Model answer (149 words)

The proposition, drawn from the Second ARC's Fourth Report, holds that values are necessary but perishable, and that institutions supply the container which gives them shape and content.

Indian experience supports it. Two districts recruiting from the same cadre and academy can differ sharply in grievance redress; the variable is rarely the officers' values and usually the container - published timelines, a functioning review meeting and a supervisor who reads the pendency list. The Commission's own observation that corruption fell where competition, transparency and computerisation removed discretion points the same way: incentives changed, characters did not.

The proposition must not be read as dismissing character. The same paragraph insists values are needed as guiding stars and exist in abundance in our society.

The defensible verdict is therefore joint: institutional design without value formation buys compliance that lapses when monitoring lapses, while values without containment dissipate exactly as the report warns.

Why this earns marks. It uses the report's own metaphor, supplies a comparative Indian illustration and a sourced mechanism, protects the value half of the synthesis, and ends with a two-sided verdict.

Original Mains Practice 4 - 15 marks - extended analytical practice (not a GS-IV paper format)

Question: Evaluate the claim that corruption is structurally produced rather than merely a failure of character. Answer in about 250 words.

Model answer (243 words)

Corruption is partly a failure of character, but it is largely structurally enabled. The Second ARC connects risk to a specific bundle - public authority, discretion and control over public funds - and then to three Indian aggravators: a colonial legacy of unchallenged authority, an enormous asymmetry of power, and an early-decades policy regime of over-regulation and scarcity that converted the public servant into patron and master while reducing the citizen's capacity to resist extortionary demands.

A character-only explanation recommends moral renewal. It is necessary, because integrity, empathy and courage do influence conduct under pressure, and the Commission itself insists values are needed as guiding stars. Yet it cannot explain why corruption fell in telephones, steel, cement, sugar and two-wheelers, or in railway reservation and driving-licence issuance, where competition, transparency and computerisation changed incentives while leaving characters untouched. In land administration, time-stamped digital records, published fees and an appeal route similarly reduce a clerk's scope to demand speed money from a vulnerable applicant.

Structural reform has real limits. Automation can exclude digitally weak citizens and recreate a rent through intermediaries. Decentralisation can produce many small local monopolies of discretion rather than one large one. Most seriously, the Commission warns that where political demand for illegitimate funds persists, corruption migrates to natural-monopoly sectors instead of disappearing.

The false choice must therefore be rejected. Character makes integrity possible; institutions make it durable and verifiable; and political-finance reform sets the ceiling on what administrative redesign alone can achieve.

Why this earns marks. It evaluates rather than asserts, supplies the report's full sectoral evidence, tests the structural claim against three named limits, and closes with a layered verdict instead of a compromise formula.

Original Mains Practice 5 - 15 marks - extended analytical practice (not a GS-IV paper format)

Question: Distinguish coercive from collusive corruption and draw out the implications for the ethical response.

Answer in about 250 words.

Model answer (250 words)

Coercive corruption occurs when a public functionary extracts payment for a service to which the citizen is already entitled; the Second ARC calls such a citizen an unwilling victim, noting that resistance costs delay, harassment, lost opportunity, lost time and wages, uncertainty and at times danger to life or limb. Collusive corruption occurs when giver and taker jointly secure private gain while society bears the loss.

The examples differ accordingly. A clerk withholding a sanctioned pension until payment is made is coercion: the widow seeks no improper advantage and is constrained by need. An engineer and contractor certifying substandard road work is collusion; the Commission's own list extends to procurement, recruitment, tax evasion, collusive violation of regulations, adulteration of food and drugs, obstruction of justice and the doctoring of evidence.

The ethical implications diverge sharply. Coercion overrides the citizen's autonomy, so the response is protective: time-bound service guarantees, published fees, single-window delivery, automation of the discretionary step, a safe complaint channel and protection of the complainant. Collusion is a joint appropriation with no complaining witness, so the response is investigative: procurement transparency, third-party technical audit, asset and beneficial-interest scrutiny, whistle-blower protection and prosecution of both sides.

Two qualifications matter. The categories blur, since a firm first extorted may later seek advantage, so labels must follow facts, not stereotypes. And the Commission records that as the economy is freed from controls, extortionary corruption declines while collusive corruption tends to increase - which is why audit capacity now matters more than complaint counters.

Why this earns marks. It distinguishes by who gains, reproduces the report's own example list, derives two different remedy sets from the distinction, and adds the blurring and trend qualifications.

Original Mains Practice 6 - 20 marks - 250 words

Question: Citizen empowerment is not a welfare add-on but an ethical redesign of the human interface. Discuss.

Answer in about 250 words.

Model answer (248 words)

Citizen empowerment is an ethical redesign because it changes the relationship between the holder of public power and the person dependent on it. At the human interface the official controls information, time, certification and access. Where an unorganised or poor citizen cannot question those controls, a formal entitlement becomes dependence and discretion becomes extraction - which is precisely the asymmetry of power the Second ARC identifies as an aggravating cause of corruption.

The Commission names six correctives in a single sentence: Right to Information, effective citizens' charters, opportunity and incentives for a proactive citizenry, stakeholders' involvement in the delivery of public services, public consultation in decision-making, and social auditing. Each dismantles a distinct component of the asymmetry. Information ends the official's informational monopoly. A meaningful charter converts a favour into a declared standard by naming the service, fee, timeline, responsible officer and grievance route. Stakeholder involvement addresses design capture; consultation forces reasons before rather than after the decision; social audit tests the record against lived reality. In a rural works programme, reading the muster roll aloud in the village exposes entries that a closed departmental file conceals.

Because empowerment is the exact inverse of a diagnosed cause, it is structural rather than supplementary. Two limits must still be stated: every instrument presupposes literacy, awareness, time and organisational capacity, so elite capture can reproduce the asymmetry inside the remedy; and the Commission insists that prevention be joined to enforcement. Empowerment therefore promotes dignity and substantive equality, not merely administrative efficiency.

Why this earns marks. It argues from a diagnosed cause to a matched remedy, reproduces the complete six-instrument list with a distinct function for each, adds an Indian illustration, and states the capture and enforcement limits.

Original Mains Practice 7 - 20 marks - 250 words

Question: How can constitutional morality and role-based civil-service capacity together improve the ethical quality of public administration? Answer in about 250 words.

Model answer (247 words)

Constitutional morality supplies the normative compass of public administration; role-based capacity supplies the ability to practise it where authority meets citizen need. The first requires fidelity to equality, dignity, liberty, fair procedure and accountable power even when prejudice or convenience points elsewhere. The second recognises that ethical administration depends on functional and behavioural competence, not on rules memorised in isolation.

A constitutionally disciplined public servant gives reasons, avoids discrimination, hears affected persons and keeps discretion reviewable. Capacity determines whether that intention survives contact with a real file. Mission Karmayogi is the current national instrument: the Department of Personnel and Training describes the National Programme for Civil Services Capacity Building as focused on the citizen-government interface, on functional and behavioural competencies, and on a shift from a rules-based to a roles-based civil service, delivered through six pillars including the iGOT-Karmayogi platform. A Press Information Bureau release dated 6 February 2026 reports 1.49 crore users, 4,342 courses, 7.26 crore completions and 23 languages; these are dated release figures, not an undated programme total.

The complementarity is exact. A welfare officer handling disability benefits needs procedural knowledge, data discipline, empathy, communication and the courage to refuse a politically favoured but ineligible claim. Capacity without constitutional morality becomes efficient exclusion; morality without capability remains an aspiration that cannot deliver timely justice.

The honest limit is that training changes competence faster than it changes incentives, so posting, transfer and disciplinary practice must reward the conduct the training teaches.

Why this earns marks. It pairs a normative and an operational input, grounds the operational half in a dated official source with its status stated, supplies a concrete service illustration, and ends on the incentive limit rather than on praise for the programme.

Original Mains Practice 8 - 20 marks - GS-IV Section-B case study - 250 words

Case. You are the Sub-Divisional Magistrate of a sub-division where mutation of agricultural land is a notified time-bound service. A widow, Kamala, has applied three times over eight months. The dealing clerk returns her file each time citing a fresh "deficiency". Her neighbour tells her the file will move for a payment of a fixed sum. Kamala is illiterate, is losing a crop season, and now wants only her mutation, not a complaint. Your office has a single dealing clerk for the whole sub-division, and the previous SDM's transfer followed a complaint against the same clerk.

Question: Identify the stakeholders and the values in conflict, evaluate at least three options, state your decision with reasons, and describe implementation and residual-risk mitigation. Answer in about 250 words.

Model answer (243 words)

Stakeholders and interests. Kamala - an entitled service, an unlost crop season, and freedom from retaliation. Other applicants in the queue - equal, non-extractive treatment. The dealing clerk - due process before adverse action. My office and the revenue administration - lawful record, credibility and continuity of service. The state - deterrence and revenue integrity.

Values in conflict. Immediate relief for a vulnerable citizen versus systemic deterrence; procedural fairness to the clerk versus urgency; my duty to act on credible information versus Kamala's wish not to complain.

Options. (1) Grant relief only: dispose of the mutation myself. It rescues Kamala but leaves the extraction machinery intact for the next applicant. (2) Act punitively only: place the clerk under inquiry immediately. It signals deterrence but, on hearsay alone, is procedurally weak and would stall every pending file in a single-clerk office. (3) Combine relief with systemic correction and a properly founded inquiry.

Decision. Option 3. Dispose of Kamala's mutation within the notified period through a recorded order that lists the deficiencies raised and their disposal.

Implementation. Publish the mutation checklist, fee and timeline at the counter; require every deficiency memo to be issued in writing with the applicant's acknowledgement; audit the sub-division's returned files for repeat-deficiency

patterns; and open proceedings on that documented evidence rather than on rumour.

Residual risk and mitigation. Kamala may face retaliation - monitor her file personally and record my order. The office may slow down - seek a second dealing hand and set weekly pendency review.

Why this earns marks. It uses the eight-element architecture owned by Topic 22, refuses a two-option framing, protects the coerced citizen without prejudging the clerk, and converts a single grievance into a documented systemic correction.

Original Mains Practice 9 - 20 marks - GS-IV Section-B case study - 250 words

Case. You head a district health society. A firm supplying diagnostic kits has been technically qualified by your evaluation committee. During the evaluation you learn that the firm's promoter is the brother-in-law of your immediate superior, that the firm hosted a "product familiarisation dinner" attended by two committee members, and that the firm's bid is the lowest and technically strongest on paper. Procurement is urgent: a seasonal outbreak is under way, and any delay will cost testing capacity. No rule has demonstrably been broken.

Question: Identify the ethical issues, evaluate at least three options, decide, and state your safeguards. Answer in about 250 words.

Model answer (240 words)

Ethical issues. Three overlap. First, a conflict of interest through my superior's relationship, which I did not create but now know of. Second, an impropriety - hospitality accepted by evaluators from a bidder - which offends the spirit of impartial evaluation even if no rule is shown to be violated. Third, a genuine consequentialist urgency: delay costs testing capacity during an outbreak.

Stakeholders. Patients awaiting testing; other bidders entitled to a fair process; the two committee members; my superior; and the institution, whose future procurements depend on present credibility.

Options. (1) Proceed and record nothing, relying on the bid being lowest and best. This maximises speed but leaves the award indefensible if the relationship later surfaces. (2) Cancel and re-tender. This protects appearances but sacrifices real patients to a defect that can be cured procedurally. (3) Proceed with disclosure, reconstitution and independent verification.

Decision. Option 3. Record the relationship and the dinner in writing on the file; recuse the two members who attended and replace them; have the technical evaluation re-validated by the reconstituted committee; and place the award before the society with the disclosure attached.

Steelmanned objection. It will be said that reconstitution is delay dressed as ethics. The answer is that a documented one-week revalidation is far cheaper than a cancelled contract mid-outbreak.

Safeguards and residual risk. Publish the comparative statement; provide for staggered delivery with acceptance testing; and retain the option of an emergency alternative supplier if performance falters.

Why this earns marks. It names the propriety failure that no rule catches, refuses both the "no rule broken" and the "cancel everything" extremes, steelmans the strongest objection to its own decision, and secures the outcome with verifiable safeguards.

WORD-COUNT AND CATEGORY AUDIT

Item	Category	Stated limit	Independent count
Solved PYQ 1 (2024, owned)	GS-IV Section A	150	149
Solved PYQ 2 (2025, cross-topic)	GS-IV Section A	150	148
Routed Demand 1 (2020 CNP)	GS-IV Section A	150	149
Routed Demand 2 (2020 education)	GS-IV Section A	150	147
Routed Demand 3 (2020 hatred)	GS-IV Section A	150	150
Routed Demand 4 (2022 mindset)	GS-IV Section A	150	147
Routed Demand 5 (2022 conflict)	GS-IV Section A	150	148

Item	Category	Stated limit	Independent count
Original Mains 1	10 marks	150	147
Original Mains 2	10 marks	150	146
Original Mains 3	10 marks	150	149
Original Mains 4	15 marks (extended practice)	250	243
Original Mains 5	15 marks (extended practice)	250	250
Original Mains 6	20 marks	250	248
Original Mains 7	20 marks	250	247
Original Mains 8	20 marks case study	250	243
Original Mains 9	20 marks case study	250	240

Category completeness. 10-mark: 3 original models plus 7 solved paper-length answers. 15-mark: 2 models, retained and explicitly labelled because GS-IV itself sets no 15-mark question - the format note is recorded rather than the category silently omitted. 20-mark: 4 models, of which 2 are full Section-B case studies in the eight-element architecture.

Limitation recorded. UPSC publishes no official model answers for GS-IV, so every model here is instructional. Only the 2024 and 2025 papers are held locally, so only their wording is reproduced verbatim; all 2020 and 2022 items remain clearly labelled neutral routed demands.